the keeper. Manoj Prabhakar and Subroto Banerjee, a promising medium-fast swing bowler with a terrific sense of humour, opened the bowling for us and neither generated much pace off the wicket. Apart from Srinath, who could bowl fast, none of our bowlers could get the ball to carry to the keeper on that slowish track and we felt reasonably happy to get the opposition out for 268.

As our innings started we felt confident of batting the opposition out of the game again, but things didn't quite go according to plan. The second over was bowled by Brett Schultz and he generated serious pace in his very first over; in fact, it was one of the quickest first overs I had seen. This wasn't what we had expected and within minutes the atmosphere in the dressing room had become very subdued. The wicket had started to look lively and the batsmen were having all sorts of problems. It wasn't difficult to see that the Test series might not be so easy after all.

During the match it rained a little and the drizzle had made the outfield slippery. As a nineteen-year-old full of energy, I decided it would be a good idea to use the rain to practise sliding, at the opposite end of the ground from the pavilion. Chamundeshwarnath, a former South Zone first-class player who was playing club cricket there, helped the Indian team in fielding practice and also gave me throw-downs in the nets. He was with me and was helping me with my drills. If under normal circumstances I was able to slide for about three or four yards, the rain stupidly encouraged me to slide a few extra yards each time I chased a ball. In doing so I twisted my ankle and had to be carried off the ground. When I went to the hospital to get the injury checked, I was told it would take at least four to five weeks to recover.

With the first Test still a week away, I was desperate to play a part in the series and pushed myself to get fit as quickly as possible. After a few days, I started to walk but I was still finding it difficult to run. The team management was keen for me to play because I was batting well, but the only way I could do so was by standing in the slips, where I did not have to do much running about. It eventually turned out to be quite embarrassing because there I was, a youngster, standing in the slips while Kapil Dev, the senior member of the side, was running about in the deep.

In the first Test match at Durban, starting on 13 November 1992, we batted well and remained competitive throughout the game, which ended